

The Rise of the US to Global Power, 1890-1919: “The Imperial Surge,” part one

- The global situation before 1890
- The Spanish American War
- The Imperial Surge in the Pacific
- Reasons for the surge

When the curtain opens, in 1893



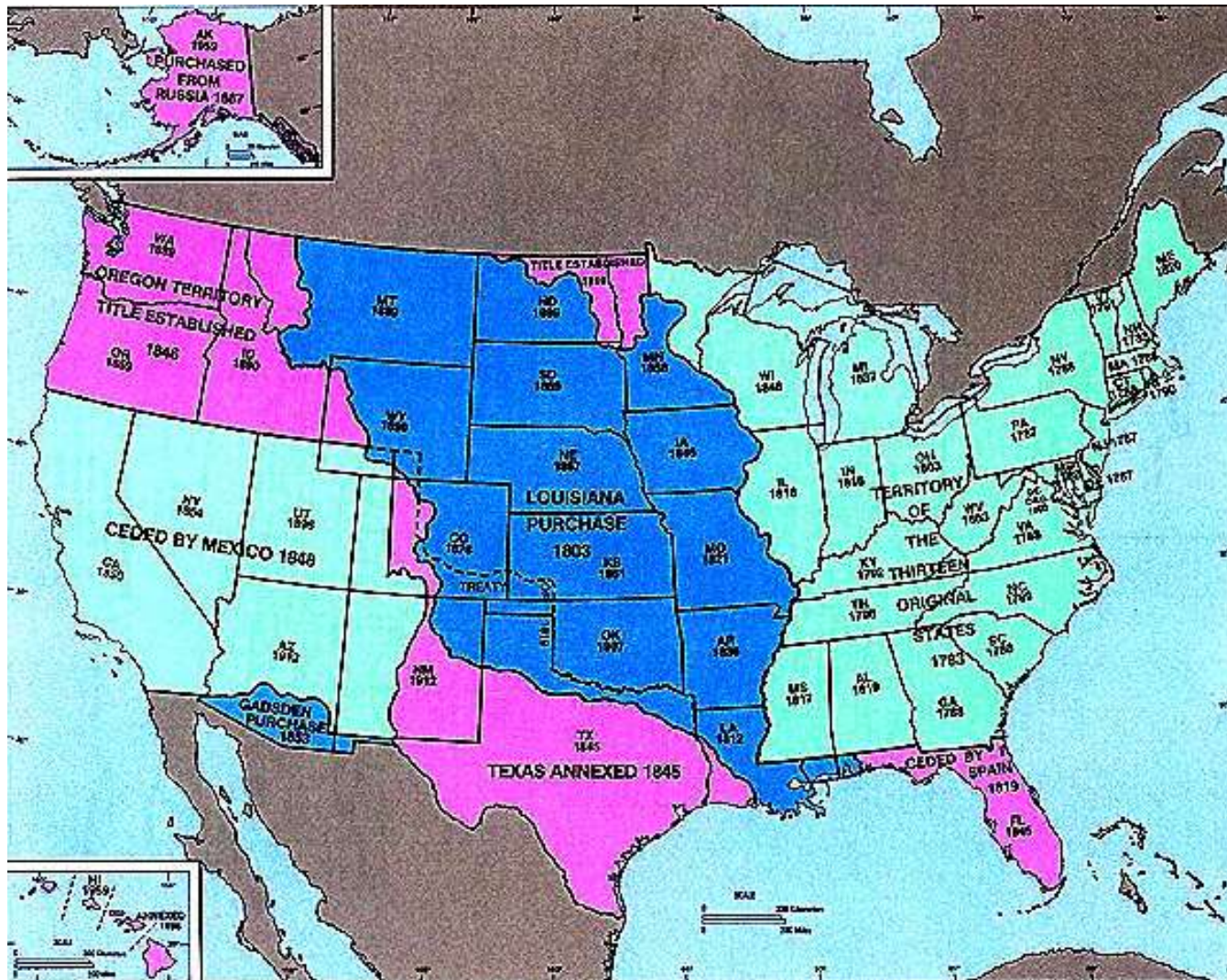
Chicago World's Fair, 1893



**Frederick Jackson
Turner,
“The Closing of the
American Frontier”**



The US frontier is “closed.”



Continental Expansion, 1776-1890

Americans tend to think of this as
“clearing the wilderness.”



“Calling dibs” on the continent



the most powerful
force in the universe...

Belief in “Manifest Destiny”

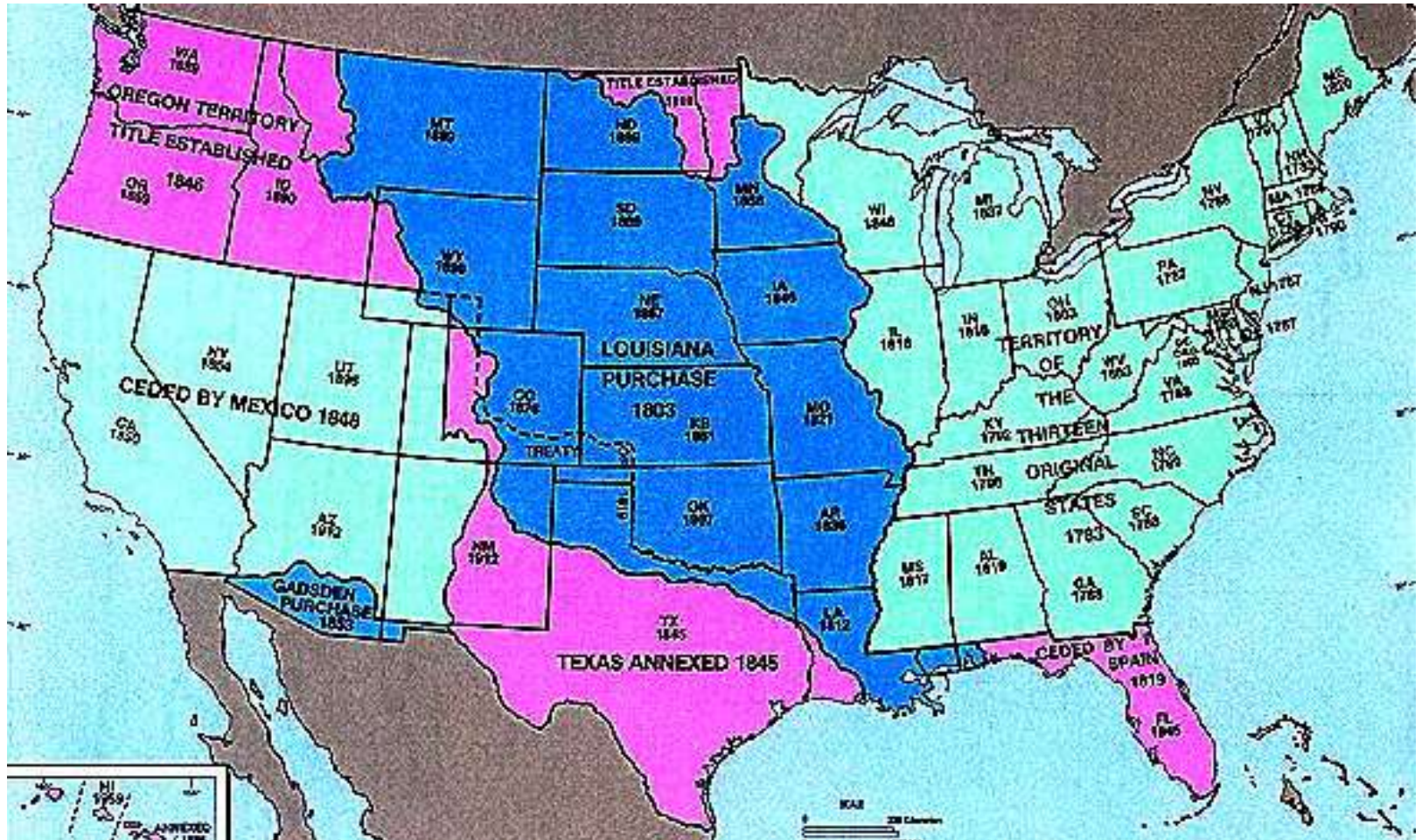


But, in fact, US expansion was like
that of other powers. It was
“imperial expansion.”

Look, for example, at Russian expansion:



Main difference: US fought a very weak
& divided enemy





Seminole Chief

The US Army was shaped by these brutal encounters on the frontier

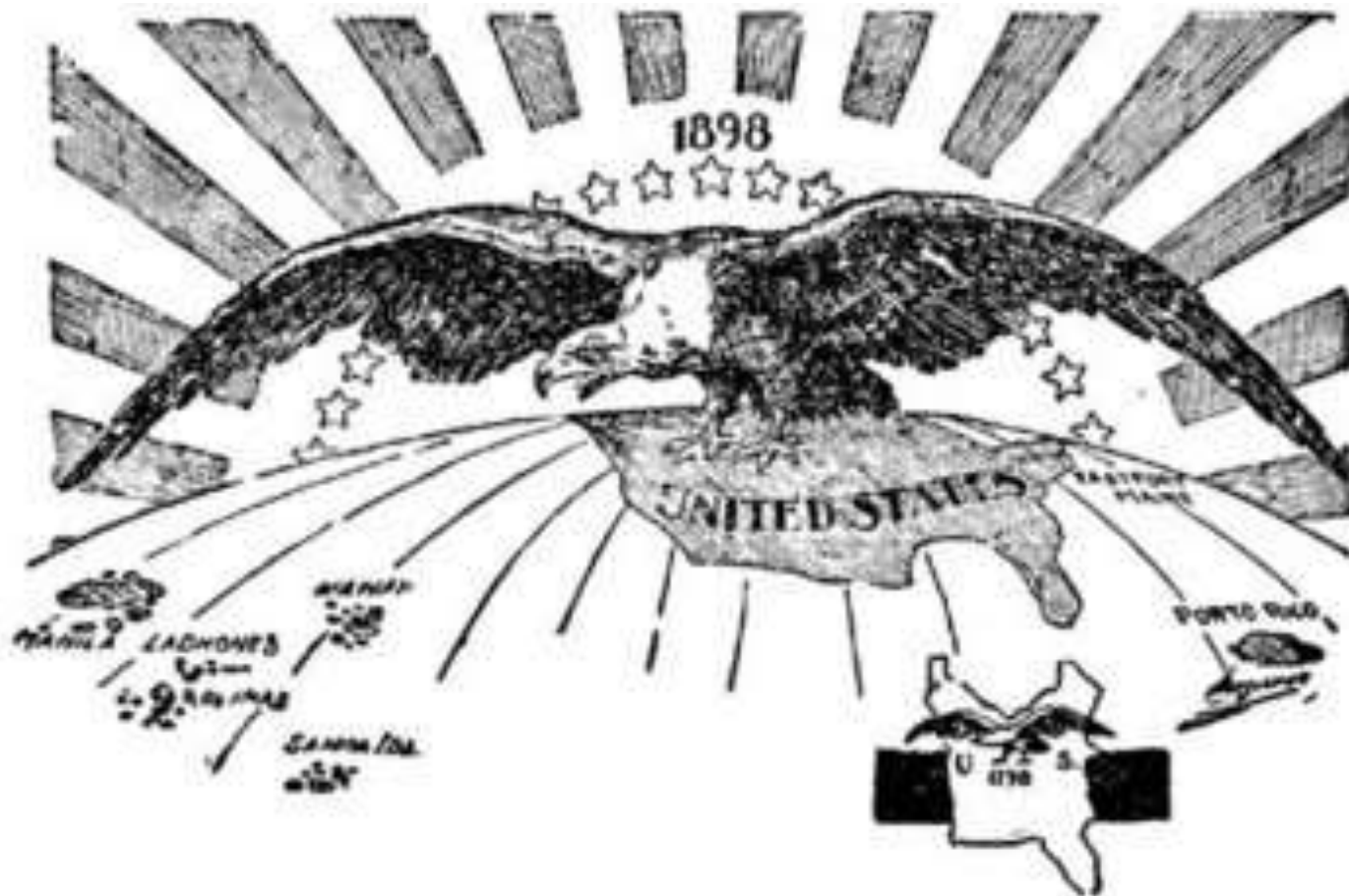


That were always fought to unconditional surrender



Burying corpses after Wounded Knee, 1891

In the 1890s – that frontier was extended
“extra-continently”



Ten thousand miles from tip to tip.—Philadelphia Press.

Loop backwards for a second:



The Monroe Doctrine, 1823

“there will be
no further
colonization of
this hemisphere.”

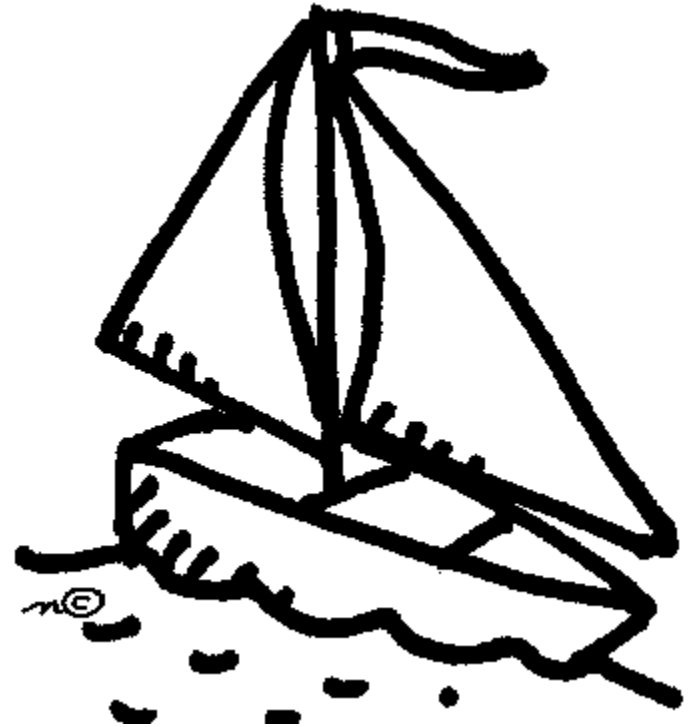


Problem:

in 1823, Monroe Doctrine =
declaration only –
an American wish.

Not a treaty or
international law.

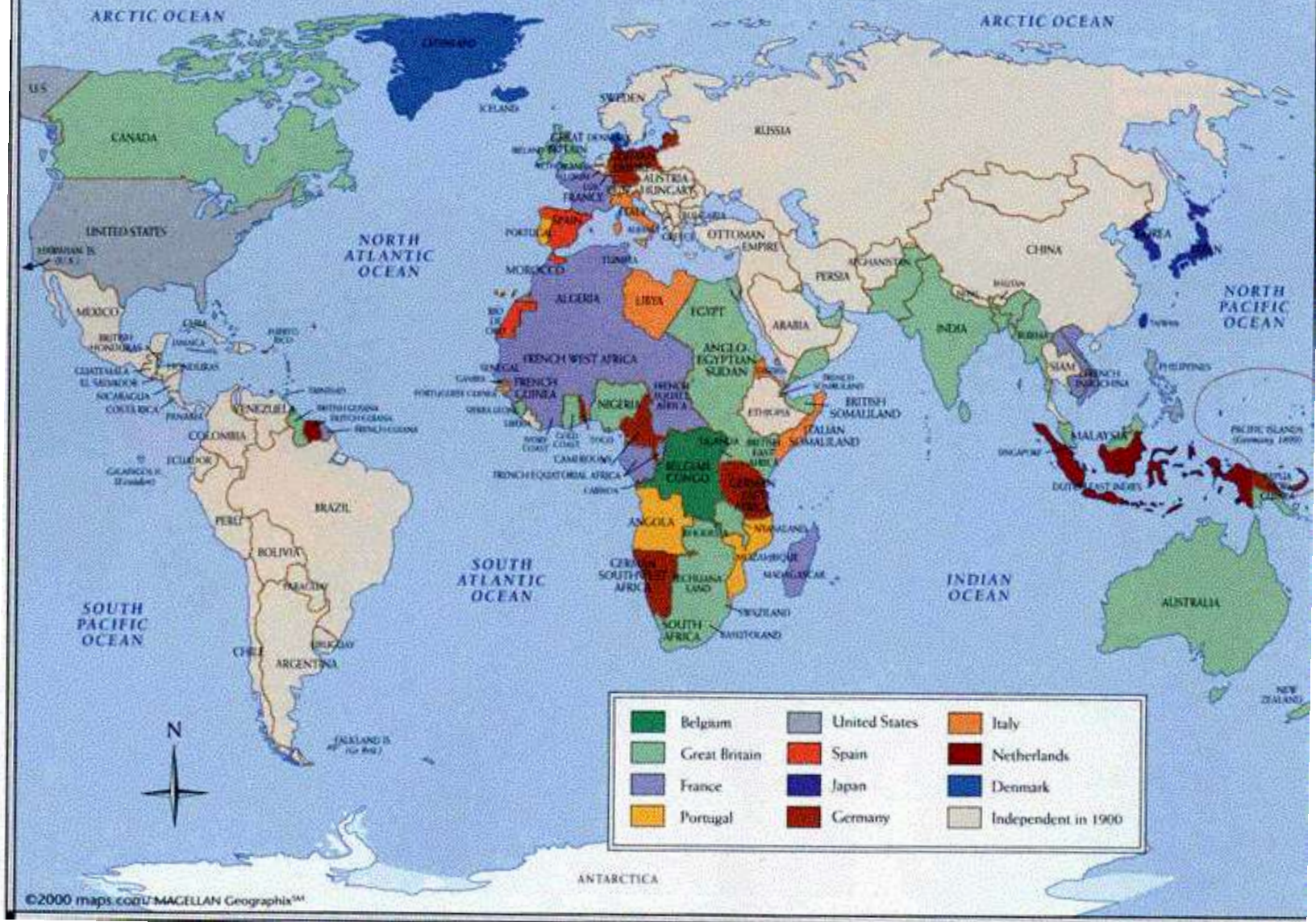
And, *US had absolutely no
way to enforce it.*



What was the global balance of
power in the 1890s

?

IMPERIALISM IN THE MODERN WORLD, 1900



In January 1898, the US had no colonies.



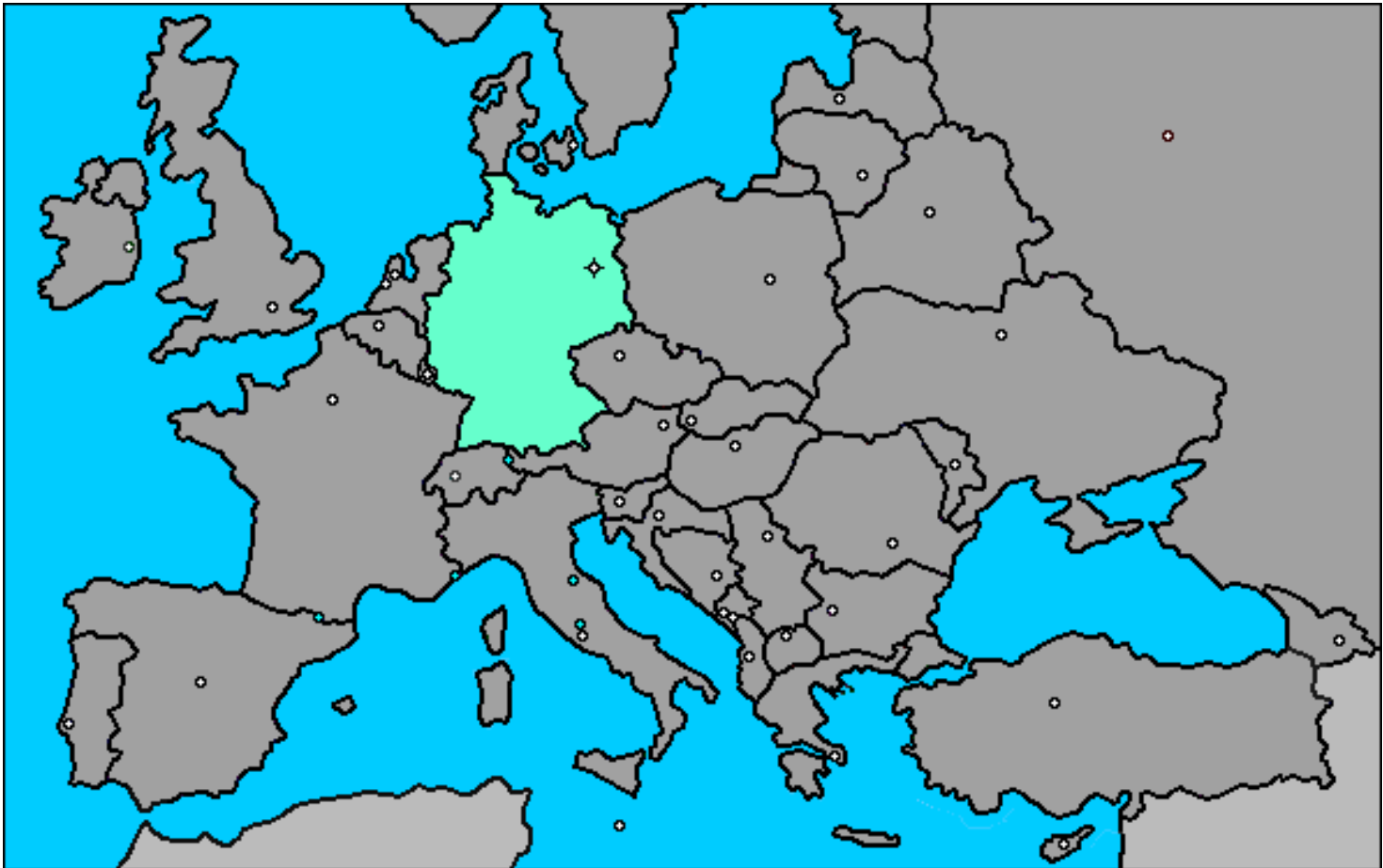
The World Situation in 1890

US was a rising economic power, but not yet one of the “big players.”

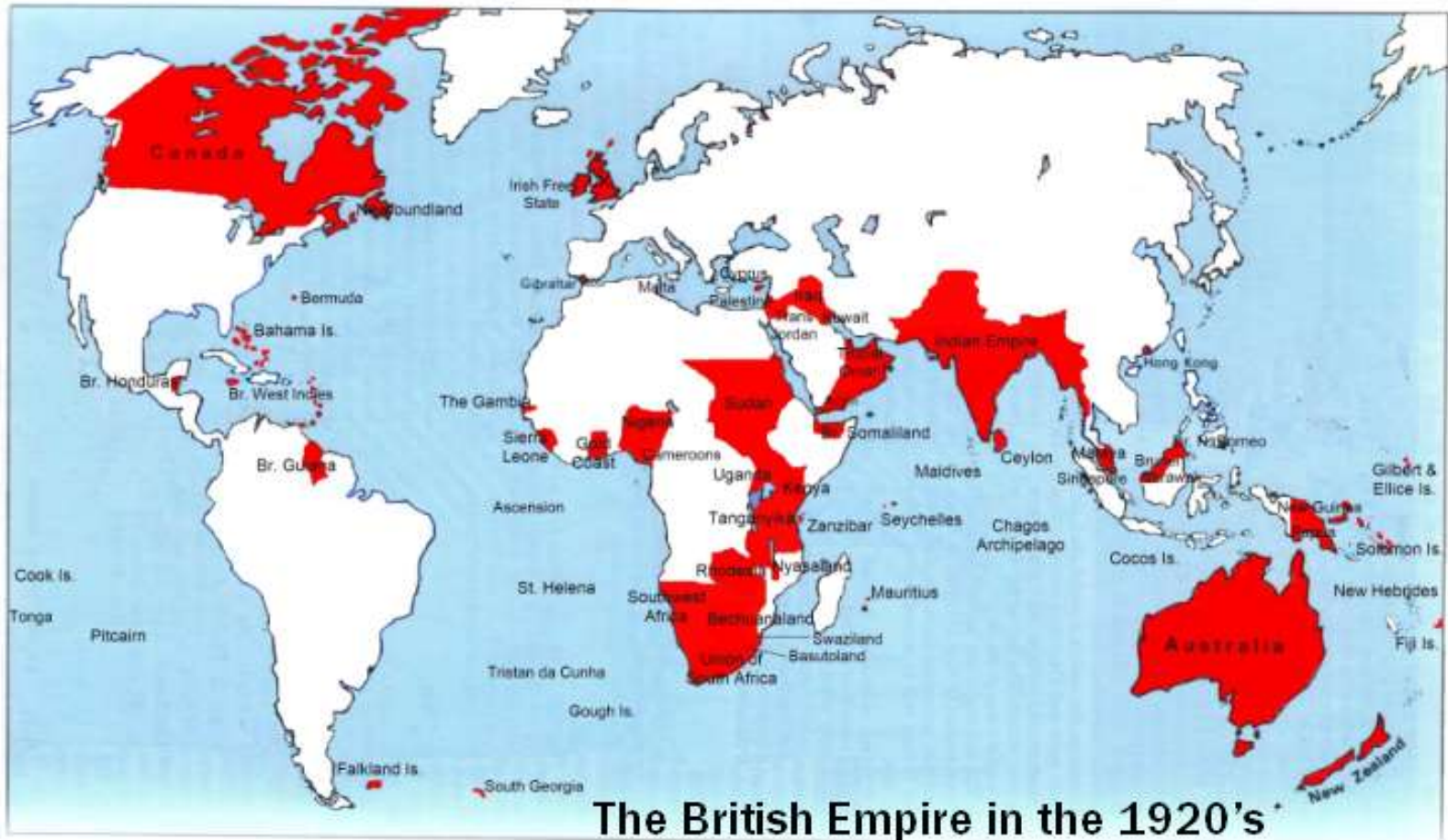
UK (Queen Victoria),
Germany, Russia, France, &
Japan carve up China. USA is
not there.



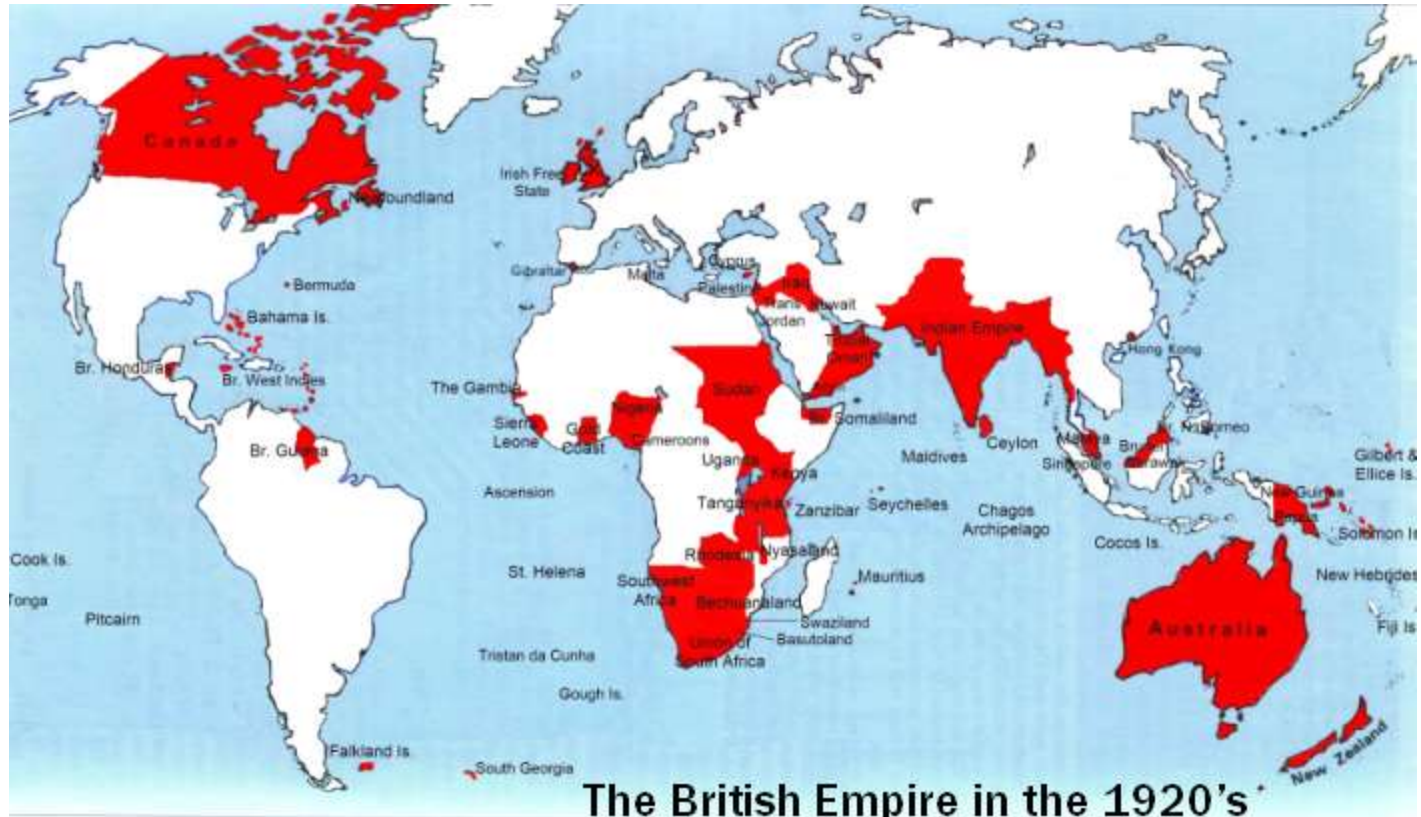
Germany was also a rising power,
economically and militarily
-- building a strong navy.



Britain was worried about Germany
and was suffering from
“imperial overstretch.”



Therefore, UK rethought
where it deployed its navy.



It wanted, above all, to protect
the homeland and India.

British- American Rapprochement

- UK withdrew from the Caribbean and "handed the baton" to the US.
- It mended relations with US.



“Better friends than they used to be”

The American Eagle + the British Lion

1898

British-American Rapprochement



“Cousins”

1898

Uncle Sam and John Bull [England] share a smoke.

By the 1890s, the US was ready to expand

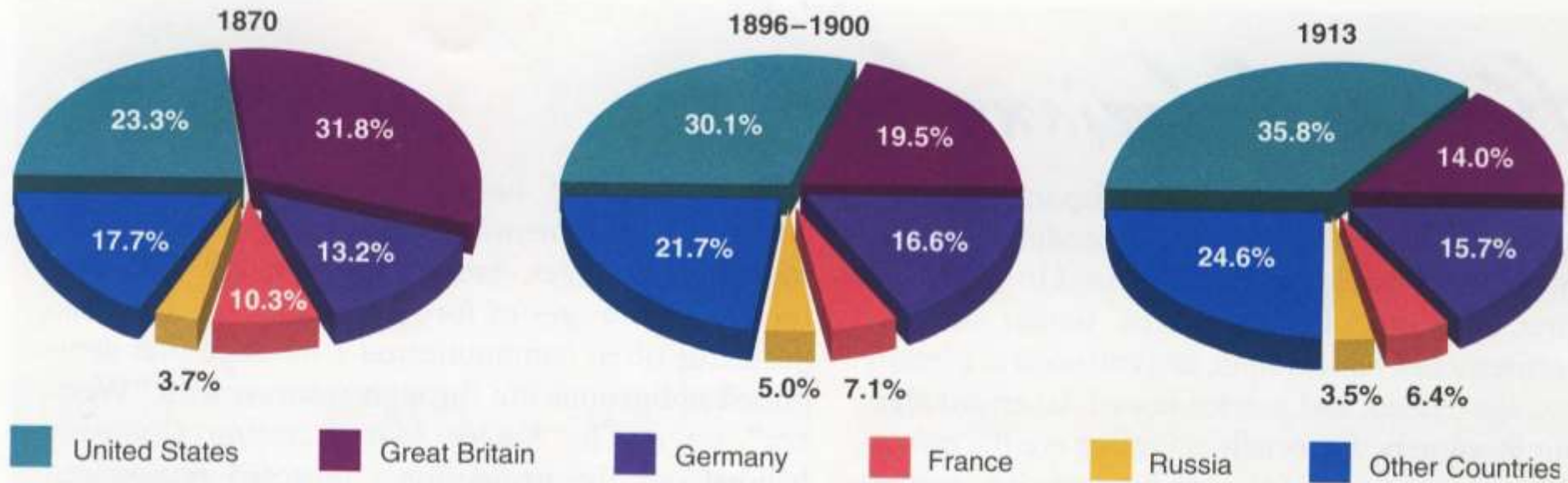


- **Industrialization:**
Increased production
 - Need for new markets
 - Need for raw materials
- **Technology**
 - steel (Navy)
 - communications (cable)
 - transportation (RR, for trade)

“A Steel Cinch on the World”

1901

Growth of US Manufacturing, 1870-1913



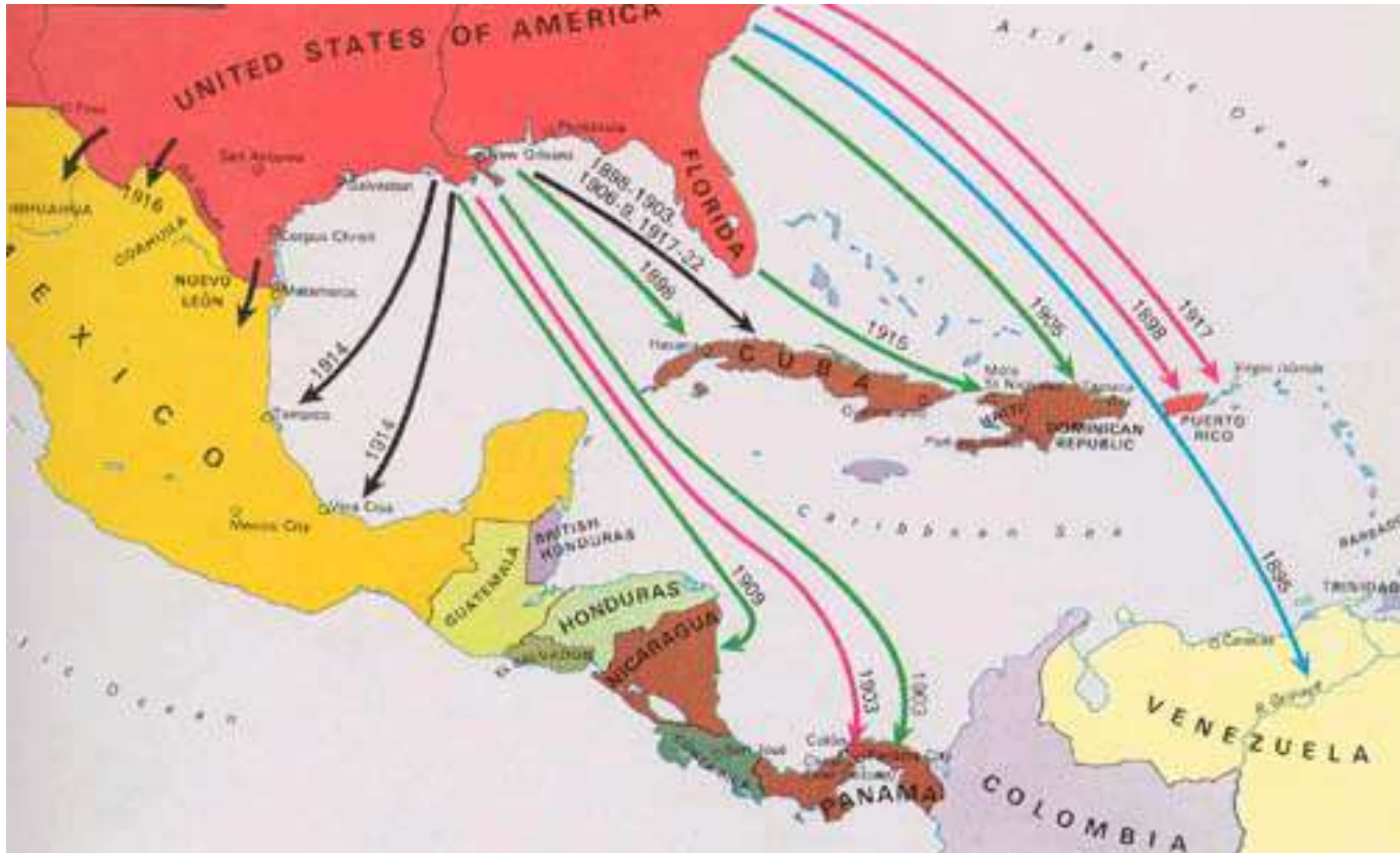
Note shrinking UK share and rising US share.

“Get out of the way!” 1897



What was the “Imperial Surge”?

(1) The Caribbean, 1898-1917





- **occupied** Cuba, Haiti, Dominican Republic, Puerto Rico, Virgin Islands
- **landed troops** in Nicaragua, Mexico, Guatemala
- **economic penetration** throughout region
- **seized Panama Canal Zone** and built canal
- **control of all deep sea routes**

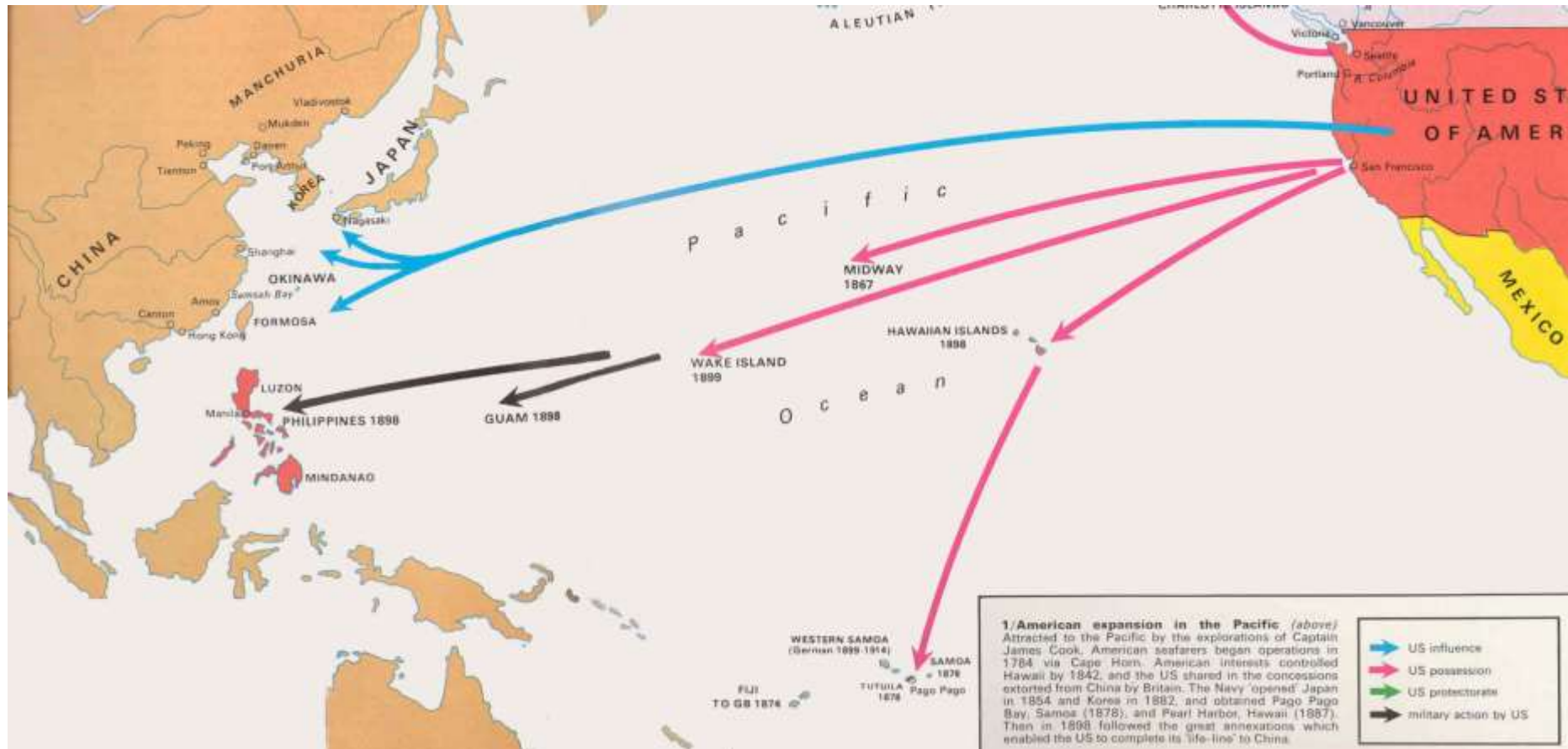
In less than 20 years: US gained total hegemony over Caribbean & Central America



**“A New Sentry in the
Caribbean Sea”**

1916

(2) “Surge” also in the Pacific, 1898-1917



1867: Claim Midway Island (no indigenous population)

1878-1889: arguments about Samoa

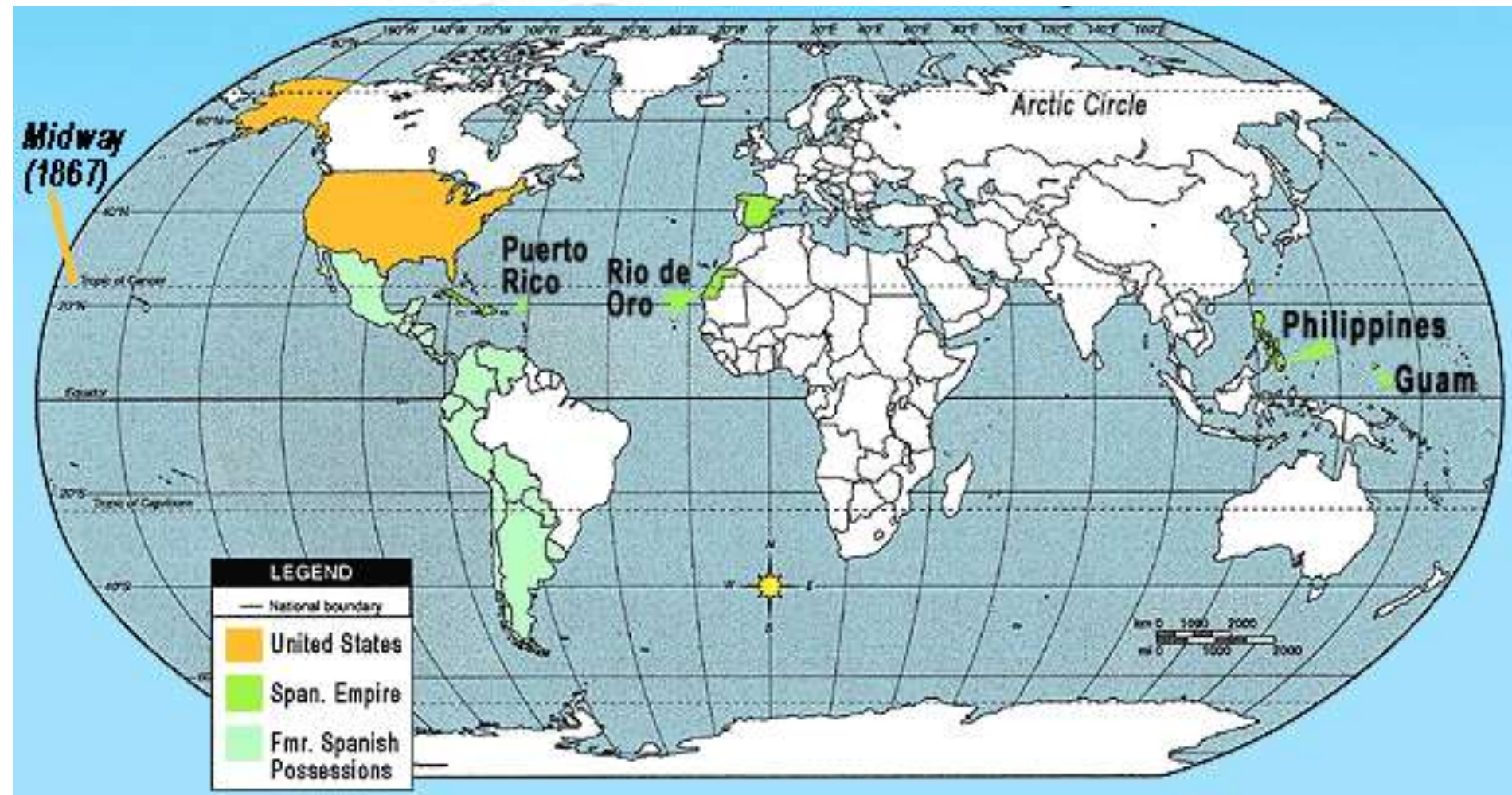
1898: Philippines, Guam, Hawaii



The Opening Salvo: The War in Cuba, 1898

Spanish Empire at its height, 1600s.

In 1898: Cuba (and Puerto Rico and Philippines) still Spanish.





Spanish rule
was harsh

1895:
Cubans begin
revolt vs. Spain
rule

“Spain’s Work”

The Cuban Revolution, 1895-1898



The Cuban leader of the revolt, José Martí, was killed in battle.

Spain crushed the revolt brutally



Spanish Prison Camps in Cuba



200,000 Cubans
– one eighth of population –
died

but it could not defeat the Cuban
insurgents.



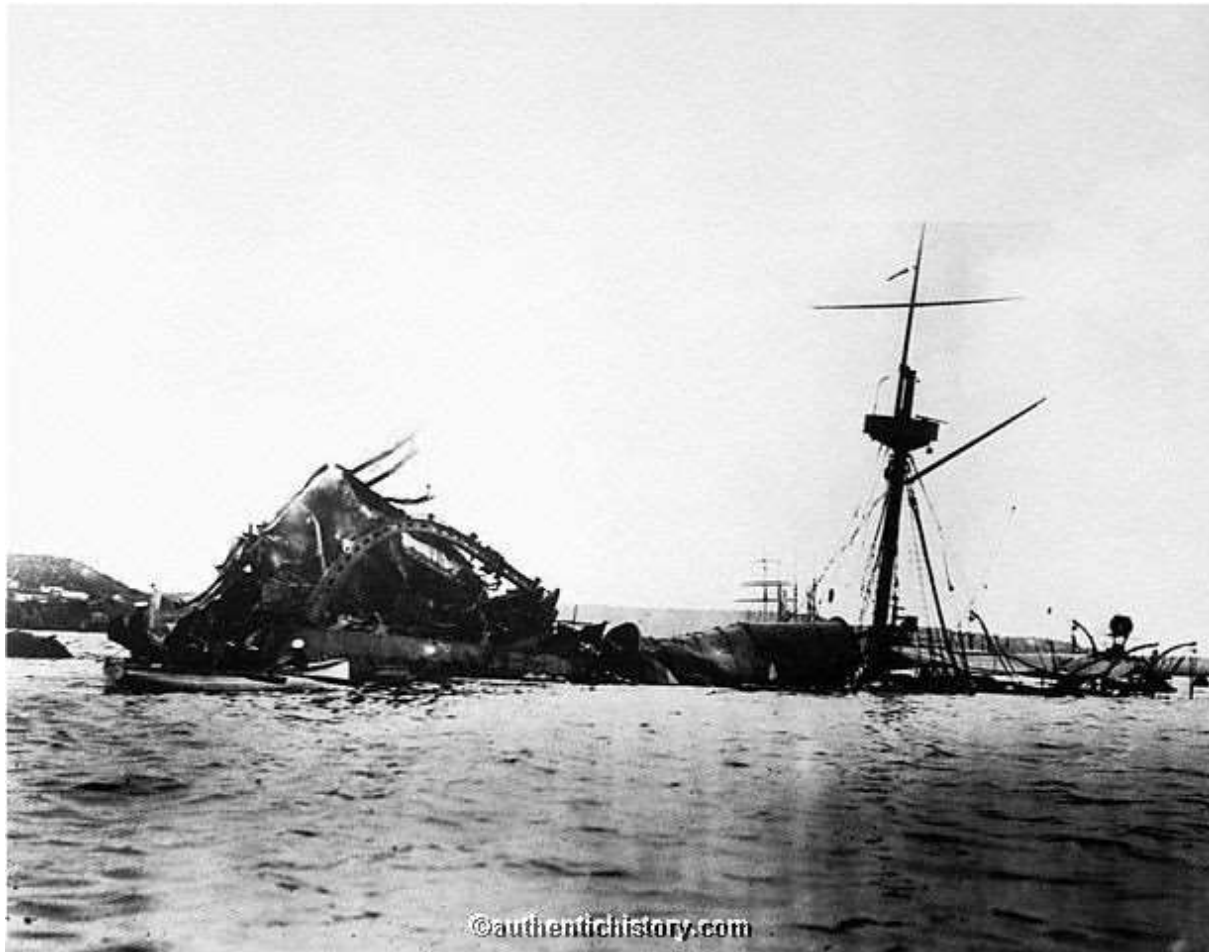
Why did US fight?



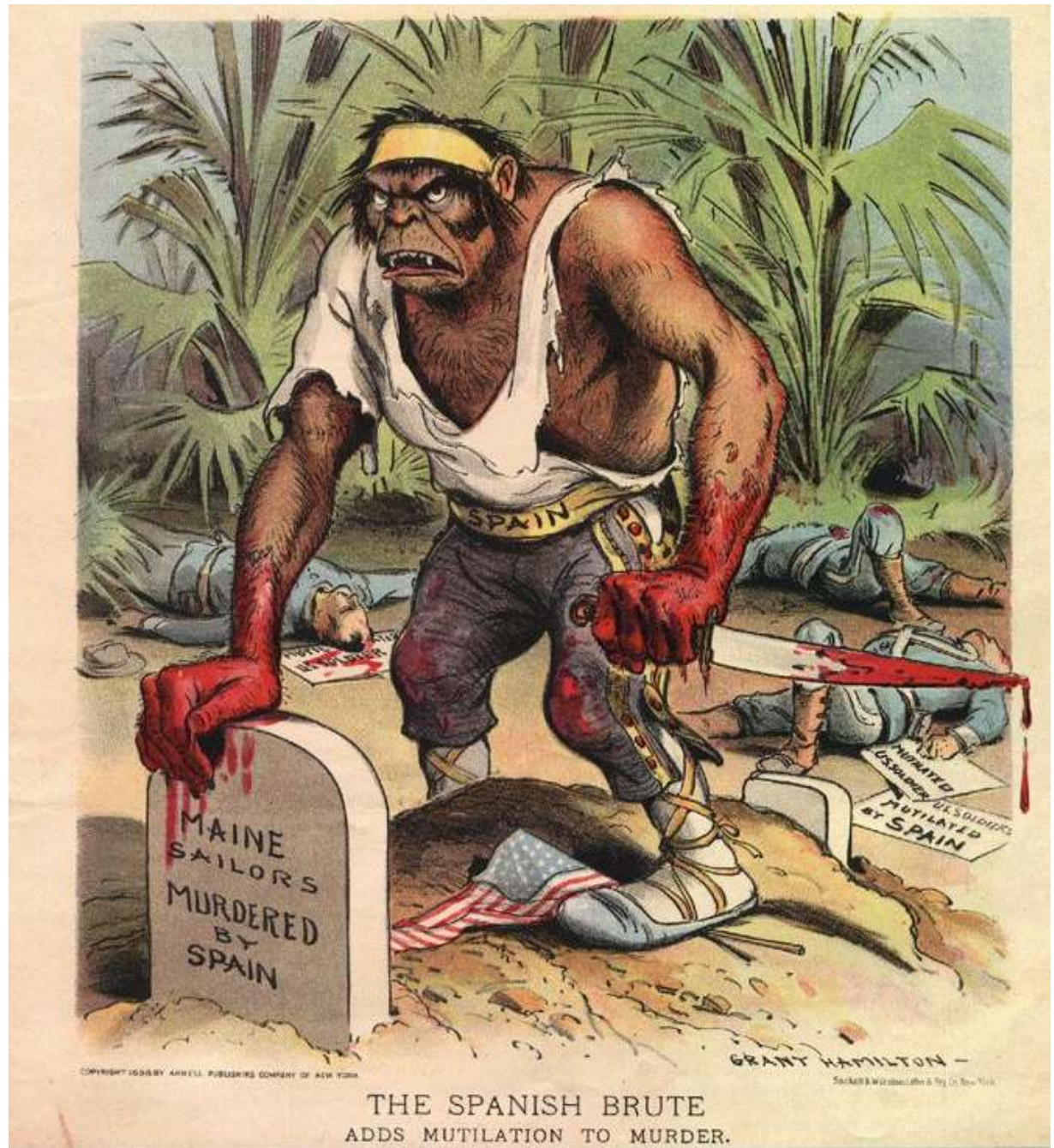
The Trigger (or last straw):

The *USS Maine* exploded in Havana Harbor, Feb. 15, 1898
266 US sailors killed

The Remains of the *USS Maine*



US
blamed
Spain for
the *USS*
Maine



“Rally Round the Flag,” 1898



This whipped up US public opinion,

already fired up
by “yellow
press” reports
of Spanish
brutality
toward Cubans.



“A Suspicious Looking Fish”

Uncle Sam, diving in Cuban waters, sees
“swordfish Spain” spearing “Cuba Libre,”
depicted as a beautiful white woman.

“War has been declared”



“The fearless yellow journals open up operations on the enemy.”

Feb. 25, 1898 (before US govt. declared war.)

**Films of war were wildly popular in
vaudeville houses.**

Movie of Spaniards killing Cuban insurgents

1898

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=fH7uqqmw>

YNw

War Fever



“Johnny, Get your Gun.”

April 25, 1898

Uncle Sam distributes weapons to volunteers for war in Cuba.

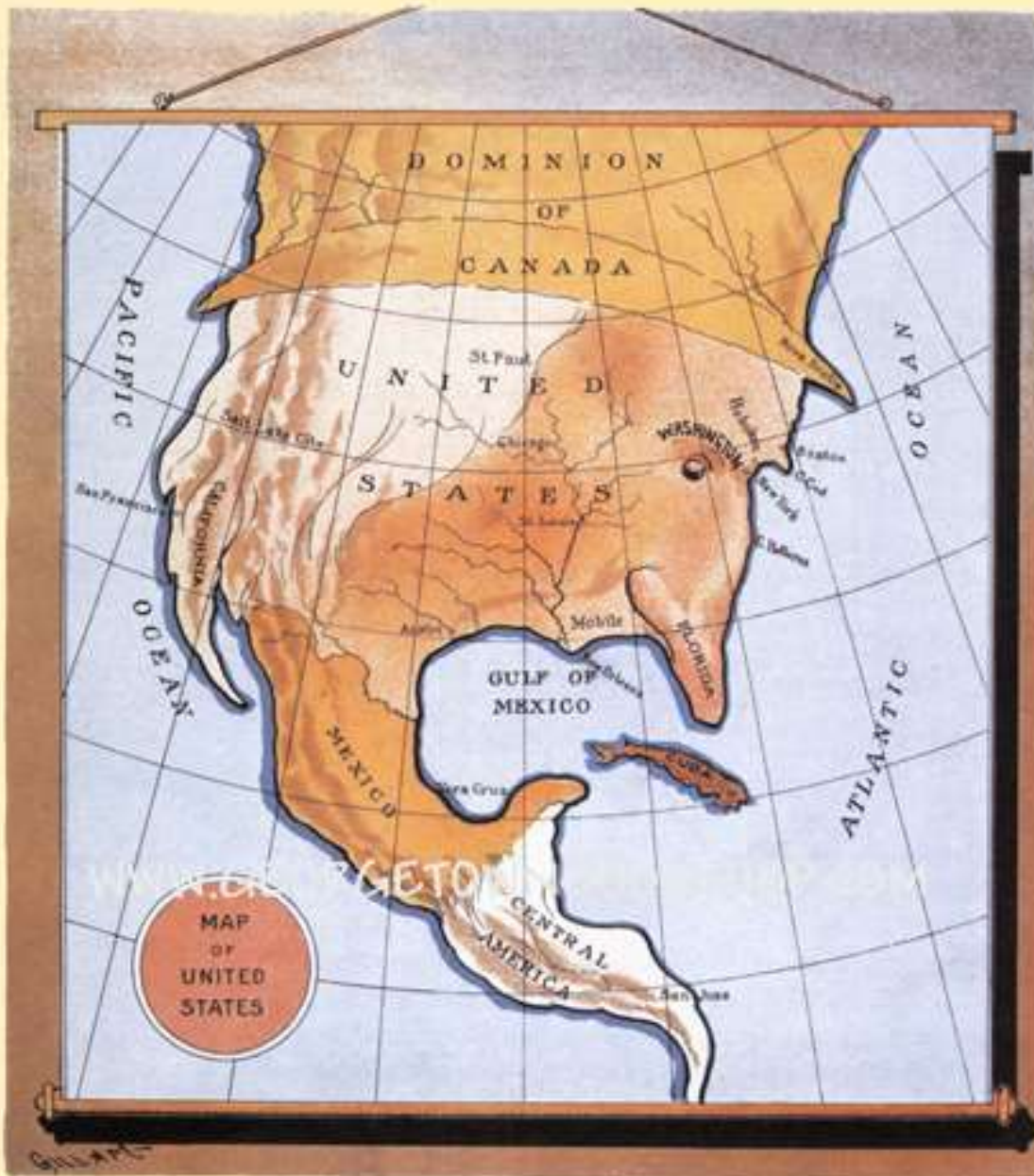
BUT underlying US motivations were complex

**(1) Ideas --
“Manifest
destiny”**



Belief that Cuba destined to be part of U.S.

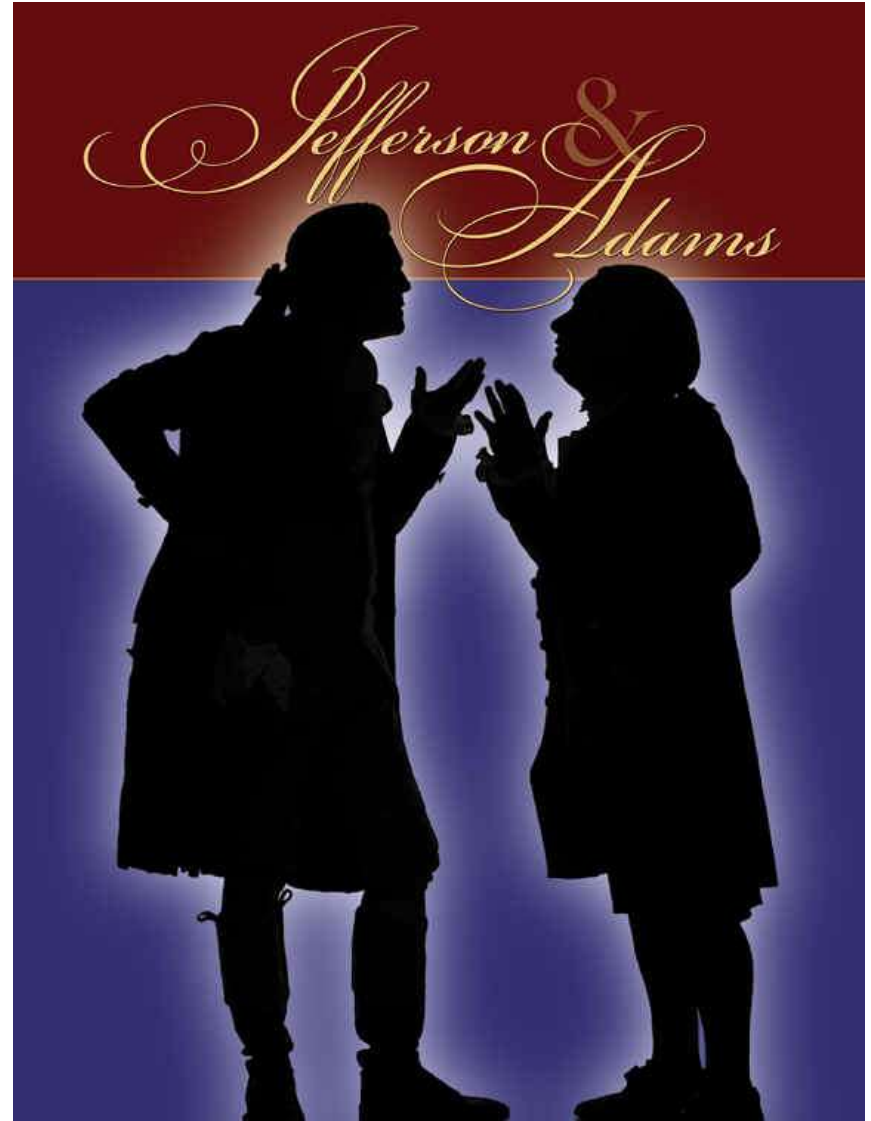
“The Trouble in Cuba”
Uncle Sam: “I’ve had my eye on that morsel for a long time. Guess I’ll have to take it in.”



THE TROUBLE IN CUBA.

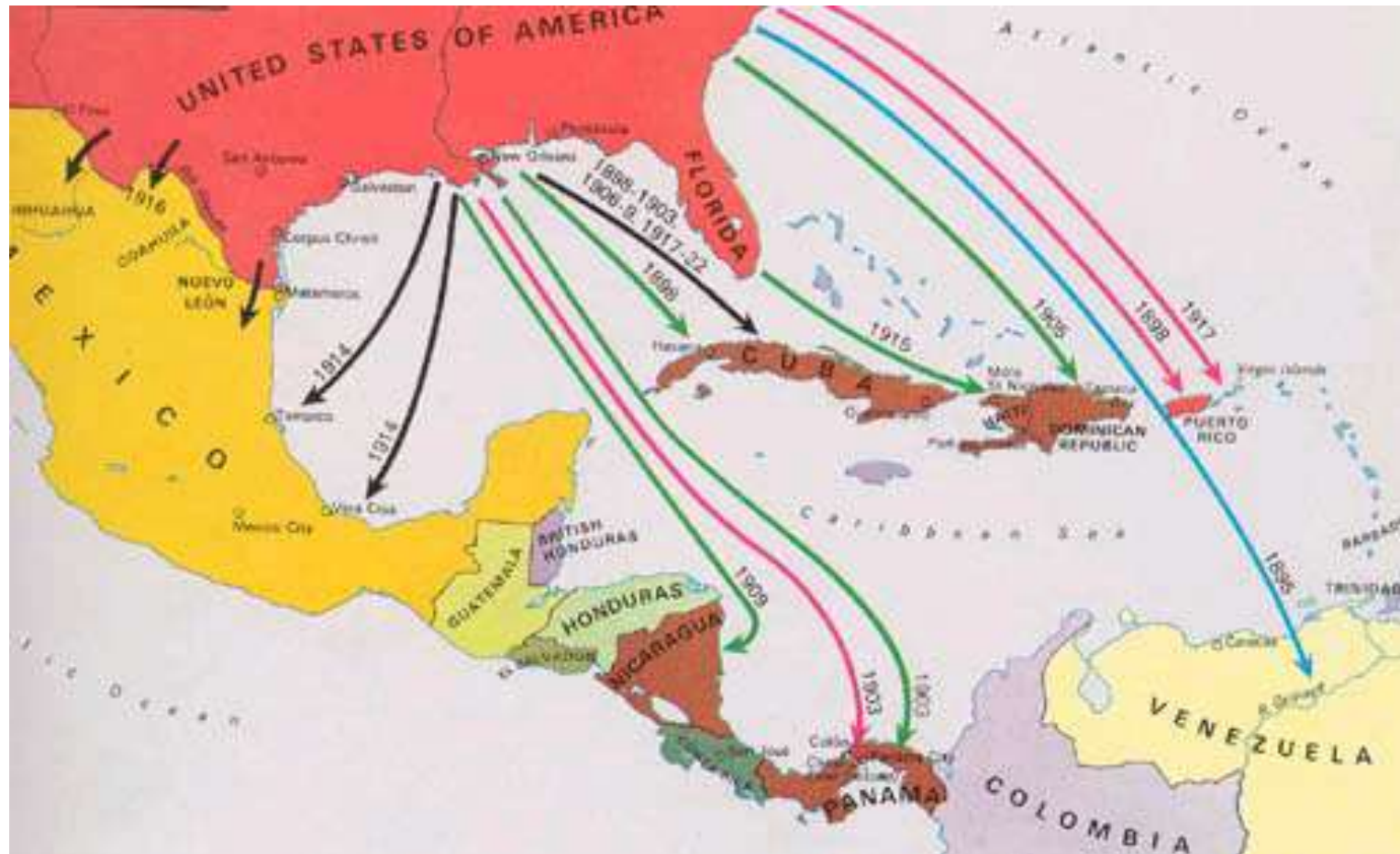
UNCLE SAM—"I've had my eye on that morsel for a long time: guess I'll have to take it in!"

- Jefferson 1809: Cuba is “the most interesting addition that can be made to our system of States.”
- Jefferson, 1817: “If we seize Cuba, we will be masters of the Caribbean.”
- Adams, 1823: predicted Cuba would fall “like a ripening plum into the lap of the union.”



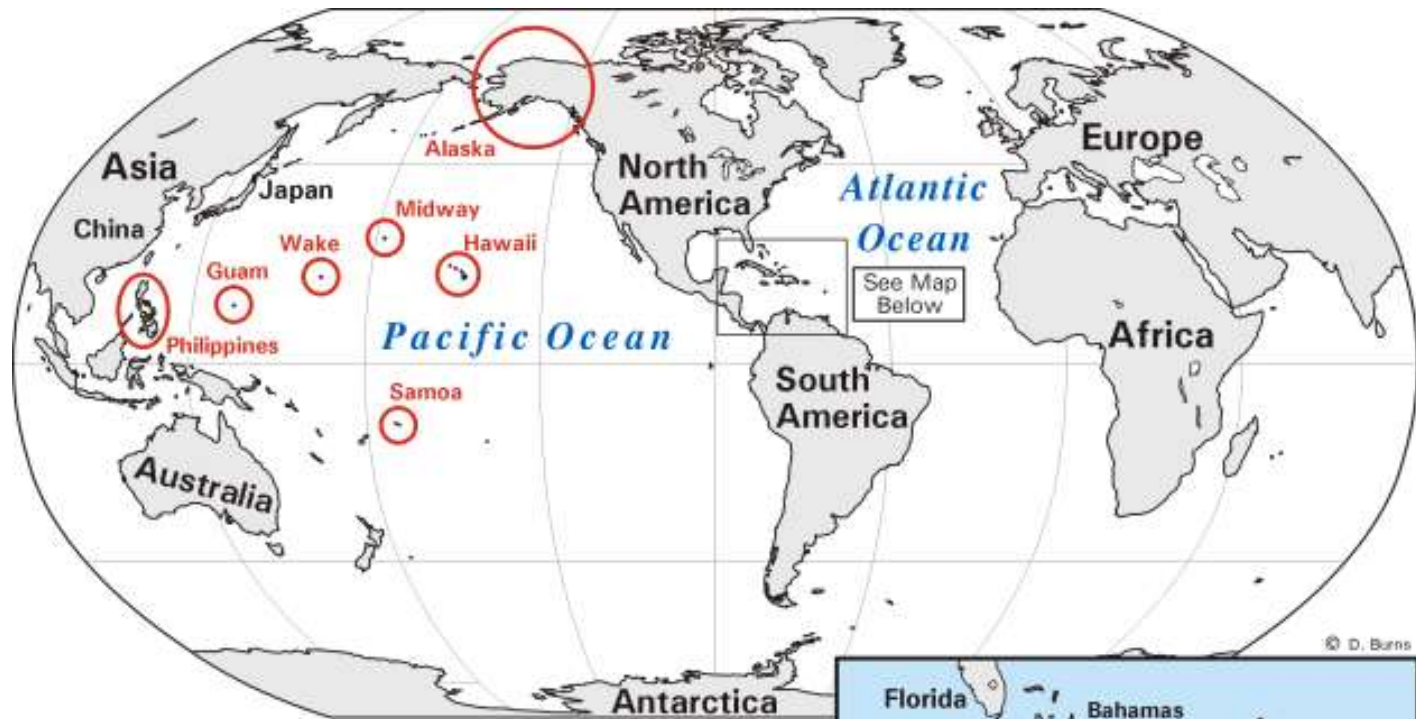
US motivations: (2) Security

control sea lanes & access to canal



US motivations: (2) Security

get
coaling
stations



America Grows Overseas

Main Areas Acquired 1865 - 1903



Robinson Projection





US motivations: (2) Security

Prevent
imperialism of
any other
power,
particularly
Germany

US motivations:

(3) Economics

US business in Cuba

- especially sugar
- US \$50 million invested in Cuba



“A splendid little war”

--Secretary of State John Hay, 1898

- Brief:
100 days,
Apr-Aug,
1898
- US Navy
trounced
Spanish
Navy



Ground war was more difficult, but less important.



Teddy Roosevelt leading charge in Battle of San Juan Hill

Results of war -- For Cuba: Cuba expected independence



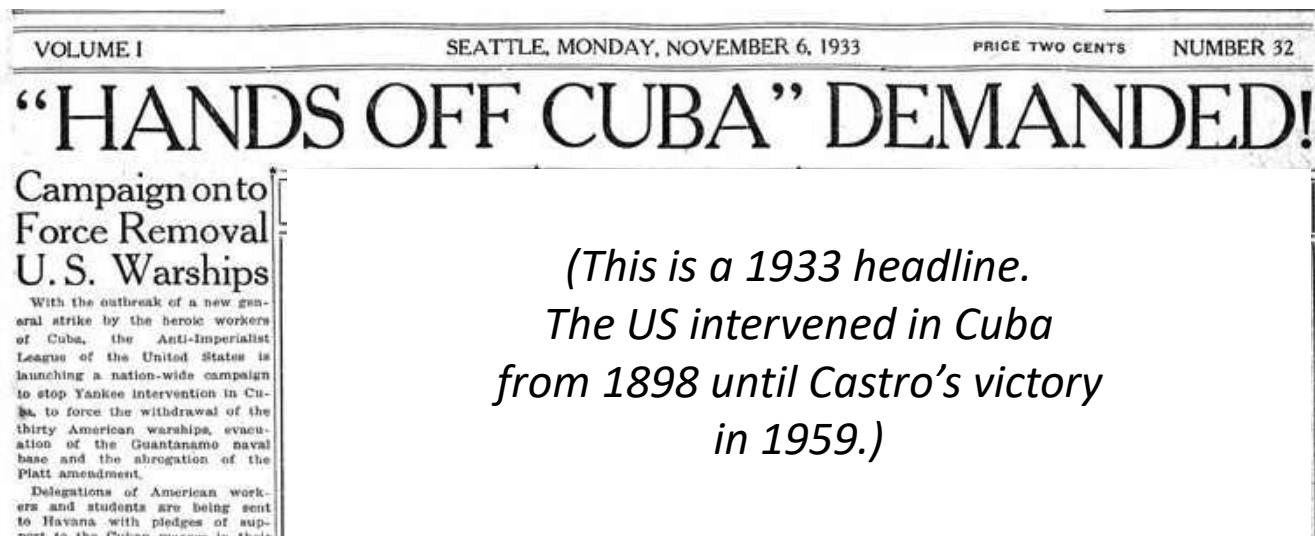
**“No room for him [Spain] on this side.”
The boot of Uncle Sam kicks Spain out of Cuba and back to Europe.
The *Cuba Libre* Flag is waving.**

Instead, it got US domination.



The US didn't establish a formal colony, but imposed the “Platt Amendment.”

- (1) Gave US the right to intervene militarily in Cuba at any time;
- (2) Gave the US a permanent naval base ...



at Guantanamo Bay, Cuba



Costs of war: For US

- cost \$250 million
- 3,000 US deaths (90% from infectious disease)



Yellow Fever

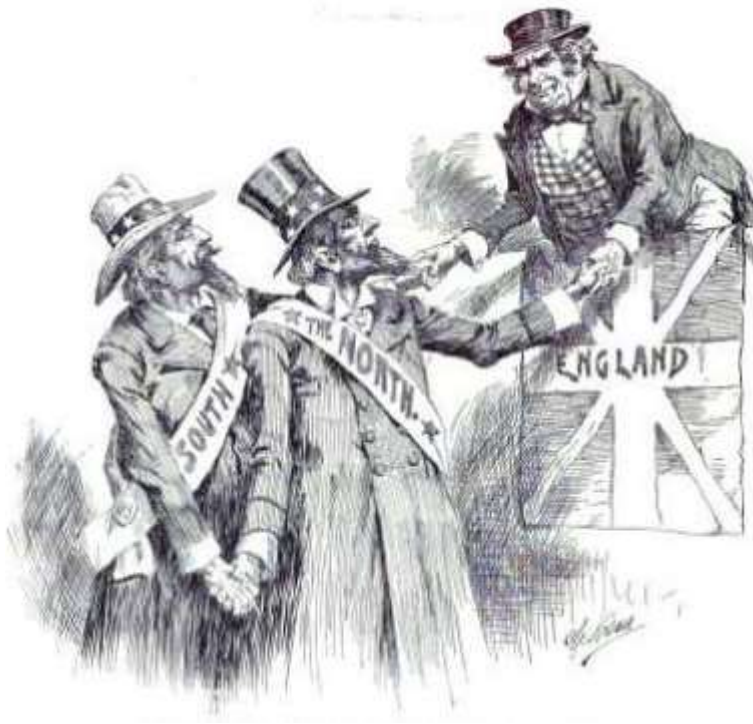
Race & the War

(note: war was in same year as Wilmington coup d'état)

- Four US Black regiments fought in the war
 - hoping to prove their patriotism
 - but Blacks in uniform inflamed whites, cf. Tampa Riot, 1898



And their contribution was ignored.



“If war bring nothing else, we are thankful.”

- The war was used to heal wound of Civil War.
- Pres. McKinley’s post-war tour of the South
 - Blacks expected him to acknowledge their service
 - but President used tour to embrace the white South.

Race: changing images of Cubans

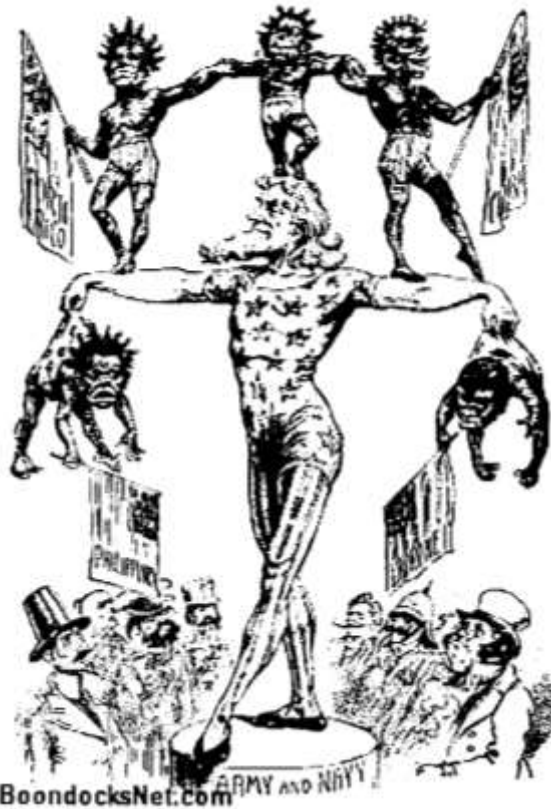
Before war: Cuba depicted as a mature, white or Hispanic woman.



"Recognition not Demanded"

Cuba: "He [Uncle Sam] need not lift his hat to me, if he will but lift his boot to Spain."

After the US intervenes: Cuba becomes a black, little boy.



“Holding His End Up”

Cuba is top right.

(Clockwise from lower left: Philippines, Puerto Rico, Hawaii, Cuba, the Ladrone Islands.



“Hurrah for the Fourth of July”

Cuba is in the center.

The war changed the global balance of power

(1) Spain declined



For Spain -- decline



“Does not know when he’s whipped.”

Voices from the ringside: “Don [Spain], you’re done for.”

“New Member of the Orchestra”



The “Concert of Europe”

**– England, France, Germany, Russia, Austria-Hungary –
welcomes Uncle Sam as one of them.**

(2) For the US – global power



“Uncle Sam, as strong man, surprises the spectators at the show.”
Uncle Sam juggles Spain, as
Germany, Russia, John Bull (UK), Austria-Hungary and Japan watch.

The war gave US control of Cuba



“Uncle Sam swings in his hammock.”
Uncle Sam fans himself on Cuba.

But what about Puerto Rico, also a Spanish colony?



“Safe!”

The US seizes the “base” of Puerto Rico, 1898

Puerto Rico, neither state nor country



Can vote in
presidential
primaries, but
not election

Presidential primary results

Democrats / 51 DELEGATES

67% 20

PROJECTED WINNER



JOE BIDEN ✓

62.4%

+ 36 Delegates

8,990



BERNIE SANDERS

14.8%

+ 8 Delegates

892



MICHAEL BLOOMBERG

14.2%

+ 13 Delegates

694

Puerto Rico, neither state not country



After
Hurricane Maria
September 2017

The War was also fought in the Philippines, a Spanish Colony

